

1. The dark gap. A vessel or aircraft that suddenly stops transmitting, then reappears somewhere else. In AIS this is called "going dark." It could be innocent (equipment failure, satellite dead zone) or deliberate (a ship switching off its transponder to hide what it's doing – common in illegal fishing, sanctions evasion, or smuggling).

2. The impossible jump. A record shows a vessel at position A, then 30 seconds later it appears 400 miles away. No aircraft moves that fast at sea level. This is called a position spoof – a vessel broadcasting false coordinates to deceive watchers. Common near conflict zones and in Gulf waters.

3. The suspicious loiter. A vessel stops in deep water for 12 hours with no obvious reason – no port, no storm, no anchorage. Ships at sea rendezvous like this for ship-to-ship transfers (STS), moving cargo, fuel, or crew without port oversight. It's how sanctioned oil moves.

4. The identity swap. Two vessels appear to share the same MMSI number, or a vessel briefly broadcasts a different name/flag. MMSI numbers are supposed to be unique like a phone number, but they're self-reported and frequently spoofed or reused – especially by vessels trying to impersonate legitimate ships.

5. The strange loop. A vessel traces a route that circles back on itself in open water with no port or waypoint to explain the turn. Could indicate a vessel waiting for instructions, patrolling, or searching – context determines whether it's a fishing boat or something more concerning.